PHOTOGRAPHIC TECHNOLOGY

OVERVIEW

Applying leadership and 21st century skills, participants demonstrate an expertise in using photographic and imaging technology processes to convey a message. Semifinalists communicate their logical processes through the on-site an interview and showcase their skills by capturing and editing photographs during the conference. The annual theme will be posted on the TSA website under *Themes & Problems*.

ELIGIBILITY

One (1) individual per chapter may participate

TIME LIMITS

PRELIMINARY ROUND

A. All components of the chapter's entry (photographic portfolio PDF) must be finished, submitted, and accessible via the Internet by 11:59pm ET on a designated date mid-May.

SEMIFINAL ROUND

A. Two (2) hours to take, edit and create a Semifinal Challenge Portfolio of photos created during the semifinal session. All editing will be completed within the challenge room.

B. Five (5) minutes to present the solution to the judges and five (5) minutes to complete an interview.

ATTIRE

TSA competition attire is required for this event.

PROCEDURE

PRE-CONFERENCE

A. Participants review the TSA Honor Statement for Competitive Events found in the General Rules.

B. Participants review the Use of Generative Artificial Intelligence (GenAI) found in the General Rules.

C. Participants access the annual theme on the TSA website under *Themes & Problems*.

D. Participants produce a photographic portfolio while observing regulations.

E. Examples of tasks that participants may be asked to perform include, but are not limited to:

1. photographing a product for commercial use
2. green screen shots
3. macro photography
4. portraiture
5. staging a still life photo using provided materials.

F. Participants submit the photographic portfolio PDF by 11:59pm ET on a designated date in mid-May.

G. Submission information will be provided on the TSA website under *Competition Updates*.

PRELIMINARY ROUND

A. A list of the twelve (12) semifinalists (in random order) will be posted on the first full day of the conference.

SEMIFINAL ROUND

A. Participants report to the event area at the time and place stated in the conference program with all of the required equipment and software noted in the Regulations and Requirements section.

B. Students will have thirty (30) minutes to set up and test any equipment. Laptops may not be taken from the room once the set-up time concludes.

C. At the end of the set-up time, the event coordinator presents the on-site challenge and related procedure to the semifinalists.

D. Challenge involves students taking photographs addressing a specific theme, or documenting a current aspect of the conference, such as a competitive event, a special focus of the site, a general session, etc.

E. Semifinalists are given two (2) hours to complete the challenge, including taking photos, editing and/or enhancing them. Editing must take place in the challenge room.

F. Semifinalists save their final photos in a multimedia presentation on their laptop.

G. Members can power down their laptop once finished, and then power them up at the presentation/interview to save battery life.

H. Laptop with the semifinal solution must remain in the room for judging and the presentation/interview.

I. Participants sign up for a presentation/interview time once the two (2) hours concludes.

J. Participants report at the assigned time and place stated in the conference program for the presentation/interview.

K. Judges assess the entries and the interview responses.

L. The top ten (10) finalists are announced at the award ceremony.

REGULATIONS AND REQUIREMENTS

Students will work to develop their leadership and 21st century skills in the process of preparing for and participating in this TSA competitive event. The development and application of those skills must be evident in their submission, demonstration, and/or communication pertaining to the entry.

PRELIMINARY ROUND

A. Participants interpret the annual theme posted on the TSA website under *Themes & Problems* to unify the photographs included in the portfolio.

B. Participants are solely responsible for all aspects of the competition, including taking the photographs, editing, and completing the portfolio. This includes images used in special effects photography.

C. Photographic Portfolio:

1. Finished album must be saved as a multi-page PDF document with the pages in the following order:
    a. Title page – must include the event title, the conference city and state, the year, the participant's ID number; one (1) page.
    b. Table of contents; pages as needed
    c. Summary of the theme must follow the annual challenge, including a detailed description of how the theme was interpreted by the participant, why the particular subjects were chosen, as well as the challenges that were faced in the selection of the subjects, in taking the photos, and in selecting and editing the final images; pages as needed.

d. Photographs:

i. Entry must contain five (5) separate images as detailed in the annual theme posted on the TSA website under *Themes & Problems*:
    1. one (1) color image
    2. one (1) black and white image
    3. one (1) Macro image
    4. one (1) Still life
    5. one (1) Student choice

    Note: Sepia tones, blue tones, or coloring of any type, other than black and white, are counted as color images.

ii. Photograph (image) can be in portrait or landscape orientation depending on the photographer. The size of the photo on the page can range from as small as 5" x 7" to as large as 8" x 10" (if portrait).

iii. All photographs must have a minimum resolution of 1500–2000 pixels on the longest side. File Format: JPEG or PNG, optimized for web (72–150 DPI).

iv. Each image must include a typewritten statement in 12-point Times New Roman font containing the following information and must precede or be on the following page after the final image. No image or photo can be on the typewritten statement page; one (1) page statement per phototgraph. Note: Statements should NOT appear on the same page as the final image.
    1. Camera make (Nikon, Canon, Panasonic, Sony, etc.). Cell phones, tablets and drones are not permitted unless specified in the yearly theme.
    2. Camera model (CoolPix, Rebel, 5D, etc.).
    3. F-stop at which the photograph was taken
    4. Exposure time
    5. ISO speed
    6. Focal length

7. A brief description of the image, how the photographer interprets it to meet the challenge criteria, and what edits were made to the original image to arrive at the final product. Include detailed information about the process/special effects applied to the image.

v. Any image submitted that combines images must have the unaltered images included in the Resources/References section of the entry.

e. A references and resources page must include a list of resources used to complete the album, including camera, software, hardware, etc.; one (1) page

f. Student Copyright Checklist (see 2027 & 2028 Forms Appendix); one (1) page.

g. Photo/Film/Video Consent and Release Forms – recognizable individuals pictured in the images (minors require parental consent) must give their written consent before the images can be used in this event (see 2027 & 2028 Forms Appendix); pages as needed

h. Resources and AI Reflection (see 2027 & 2028 Forms Appendix); maximum of four (4) pages

D. All prints used in this event should be appropriate for viewing at the National TSA Conference. Any entry that includes images depicting inappropriate or unacceptable behavior may result in disqualification.

SEMIFINAL ROUND

A. Semifinalists are required to provide their own equipment and any other related accessories needed to complete the semifinals portfolio presentation. These can include but not limited to the following:

1. A tripod
2. Portable, off-camera flash unit (e.g., a speedlight)
3. Cell phone cameras are not permitted.
4. A computer (laptop is preferred) with graphic editing software installed. The laptop must be fully charged with enough battery for the semifinal round.
5. One (1) computer mouse (if desired)
6. Portable power bank (if desired)
7. Students will save their work to their computer and will present their solution to the judges during the semifinal interview.

B. Participants use the graphic editing software (e.g., Lightbox, Photoshop, Fireworks, etc.), to edit their images.

C. Each semifinalist must have a method to transfer the images to the computer for editing (such as a media reader).

D. No internet access or electricity will be provided. If using student provided hotspot, National TSA does not guarantee reliable connectivity during the event.

E. Semifinalist portfolio MUST include the following information using 12-point Times New Roman font for all text:

1. Photo 1, Page 1
   a. Copy of the original, unedited image
2. Photo 1, Page 2
   a. Copy of final digital photograph
3. Photo 1, Page 3
   a. Camera make (Nikon, Canon, Panasonic, Sony, etc.)
   b. Camera model (CoolPix, Rebel, 5D, etc.)
   c. F-stop at which each photograph was taken
   d. Exposure time of each photograph
   e. ISO speed of each photograph
   f. Focal length of the lens for each photograph
   g. Brief statement (one to two sentences in length) on how the photographer believes the image meets the challenge (e.g., “I chose a standard formal portrait style in black and white to focus attention on the subject’s face.”).
   h. Detailed description of the edits made to the original image to arrive at the final image.

4. Photo 1, Page 4
    a. Resources and References (if applicable). Images used in special effects photos (composite images, ghosted images, etc.) are to be placed in this section and should note the associated photo.

Note: The above portfolio regulations are in addition to any special requirements communicated during the semifinal round informational session. If the challenge requires multiple photos, each photo will include the same four pages.

F. Once in the semifinalist room at the assigned time, the participants will have two (2) minutes to open the presentation and prepare for their interview using the participants laptop. The setup time is not counted towards the presentation and interview time.

G. Participants are responsible for providing a charged laptop to view their semifinalist presentation. No access to power will be provided.

H. The member will give a brief presentation that details the thought processes creating each image of the semifinal portfolio allowing for time to answer interview questions. The presentation and interview will be five (5) minutes to present the solution to the judges and five (5) minutes to complete an interview.

I. Judges will independently assess the entries and interview responses.

J. The top ten (10) finalists are announced at the awards ceremony.

K. All prints used in this event should be appropriate for viewing at the National TSA Conference. Any entry that includes images depicting inappropriate or unacceptable behavior will result in disqualification.

EVALUATION

PRE-CONFERENCE/PRELIMINARY ROUND

A. Photographic portfolio

SEMIFINAL ROUND

A. Semifinalist portfolio

B. Interview

Refer to the official rating form for more information.

GENERATIVE ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE

Generative Artificial Intelligence (GenAI) is permitted for this event. Refer to the Use of Generative Artificial Intelligence (GenAI) for Competitive Events found in the General Rules and Regulations.

STEM INTEGRATION

This event aligns with the STEM (Science, Technology, Engineering, and Mathematics) educational standards.

LEADERSHIP AND 21ST CENTURY SKILLS

This event provides opportunity for students to build and develop leadership and 21st century skills including but not limited to – Communication, Collaboration/Social Skills, Initiative, Problem Solving/Risk Taking, Critical Thinking, Perseverance/Grit, Creativity, Relationship Building/Teamwork, Dependability/Integrity, and Flexibility/Adaptability

CAREERS RELATED TO THIS EVENT

This competition has connections to one (1) or more of the careers below:

- Advertising or public relations executive
- Graphic designer
- Photographer

Participant/Team ID# _____

PHOTOGRAPHIC TECHNOLOGY

2027 & 2028 OFFICIAL RATING FORM

HIGH SCHOOL

Judges: Using minimal (1-4 points), adequate (5-8 points), or exemplary (9-10 points) performance levels as a guideline in the rating form, record the scores earned for the event criteria in the column spaces to the right. The X1 or X2 notation in the criteria column is a multiplier factor for determining the points earned. (Example: an "adequate" score of 7 for an X1 criterion = 7 points; an "adequate" score of 7 for an X2 criterion = 14 points.) A score of zero (0) is acceptable if the minimal performance for any criterion is not met.

Go/No Go Specifications

- Before judging the entry, ensure that the items below are present; indicate presence with a check mark in the box.
- If an item is missing, leave the box next to the item blank and place a check mark in the box labeled ENTRY NOT EVALUATED.
- If a check mark is placed in the ENTRY NOT EVALUATED box, the entry is not to be judged.

☐ PDF of the photographic portfolio was submitted

☐ ENTRY NOT EVALUATED

PRELIMINARY PHOTOGRAPHIC PORTFOLIO (90 points)				
CRITERIA	Minimal performance	Adequate performance	Exemplary performance	Record scores in the column spaces below.
	1-4 points	5-8 points	9-10 points	
Portfolio (X1)	Portfolio is missing several components and/or is lacking in quality.	Most components are included: portfolio is generally organized and displays some quality in fonts and layout.	All components are included; effort and quality of work are evident; portfolio displays high quality choice of fonts and layouts.	
Principles and Elements of Design and Composition and Creativity (X2)	There is little or no evidence of an understanding or creative use of compositional elements (line, shape, form, value, space, texture, color, framing, emphasis, balance, unity, contrast, movement/rhythm and pattern/repetition).	Images demonstrate some knowledge and creative use of compositional elements (line, shape, form, value, space, texture, color, framing, emphasis, balance, unity, contrast, movement/rhythm and pattern/repetition).	Images clearly demonstrate excellent and creative use of a variety of compositional elements (line, shape, form, value, space, texture, color, framing, emphasis, balance, unity, contrast, movement/rhythm and pattern/repetition).	
Technical Quality (X1)	Photos are out of focus; blurriness is unintentional and does not contribute to the overall composition; photos display incorrect exposure values, white balance, and/or range of tones; there is little or no consideration given to lighting and/or special effects.	Photos are in focus; photos display correct exposure values, white balance, and/or range of tones; images exhibit some attention to lighting and/or the use of special effects.	Photo subject(s) are in sharp focus; blurriness is used effectively to enhance the composition; photos display correct exposure values, white balance, and/or range of tones; images are enhanced by attention to lighting and/or the use of special effects.	
Impact and Theme (X2)	Images are flat and lack emotional depth; viewers are not drawn into the scene; images do not clearly convey the theme/challenge.	Images show some emotional depth; viewers make an emotional connection with the images/pictures and are drawn into the scene or learn something from the subject(s); images convey the competition theme/challenge.	Images show emotional depth; viewers make an instant emotional connection with the pictures and are drawn into the scene or learn something from the subject(s); images cleary convey the competition theme/challenge.	

PRELIMINARY PHOTOGRAPHIC PORTFOLIO (90 points) – continued				
Written Statements (X1)	A written statement may or may not accompany each photo, and/or the statement includes only some of the photo's meta data (camera make/model, f/stop, exposure time, ISO speed, focal length), and/or an explanation of the relevance of the image to the challenge is not present and/or is written poorly.	A written statement accompanies each photo; statement includes most of the photo's meta data (camera make/model, f/stop, exposure time, ISO speed, focal length); an explanation of the relevance of the image to the challenge is included.	A written statement accompanies each photo; statement includes the photo's meta data (camera make/model, f/stop, exposure time, ISO speed, focal length); an explanation of the relevance of the image to the challenge is presented in a clear and concise manner.	
Resources/ References (X1)	A reference list is present, but graphic and/or software packages used are not mentioned, and/or appropriate format is not used, and/or the citations are inadequate.	A reference list is present and the primary software packages used are included; appropriate format is used for an adequate number of resources.	Detailed and concise resources/ references are provided; all software packages used are included; appropriate format is used for the citations.	
Resources and AI Reflection (X1)	Form is incomplete or vague and does not clearly explain whether or how AI was used, showing little connection to the submission or understanding of effectiveness and ethics.	Form is complete and clearly explains AI use or the lack thereof with connections to the submission or theme/topic (when applicable), addressing effectiveness and ethical considerations with adequate analysis.	Form is complete, concise, and specific, critically evaluating how AI or non-AI tools shaped decisions and outcomes, with strong alignment to the submission or theme/topic (when applicable) and ethical reasoning.	
			PRELIMINARY PHOTOGRAPHIC PORTFOLIO SUBTOTAL (90 points)	

Rules violations (a deduction of 20% of the total possible points for the above sections) must be initialed by the judge, coordinator, and manager of the event. Record the deduction in the space to the right.

Indicate the rule violated: _____

PRELIMINARY SUBTOTAL (90 points)

SEMIFINALIST PORTFOLIO/INTERVIEW (80 points)				Record scores in the column spaces below.
CRITERIA	Minimal performance	Adequate performance	Exemplary performance	
	1-4 points	5-8 points	9-10 points	
Principles and Elements of Design/ Composition and Creativity (X1)	There is little or no evidence of an understanding or creative use of compositional elements (line, shape, form, value, space, texture, color, framing, emphasis, balance, unity, contrast, movement/rhythm and pattern/repetition).	Images demonstrate some knowledge and creative use of compositional elements (line, shape, form, value, space, texture, color, framing, emphasis, balance, unity, contrast, movement/rhythm and pattern/repetition).	Images clearly demonstrate excellent and creative use of a variety of compositional elements (line, shape, form, value, space, texture, color, framing, emphasis, balance, unity, contrast, movement/ rhythm and pattern/repetition).	
Technical Skill (X2)	Participants do not demonstrate knowledge of and understanding of how to utilize photographic equipment and techniques such as lighting equipment, and/or off-camera flash, or do not use it altogether in the on-site challenge; participants show little or no creativity in staging and photographing subjects.	Participants demonstrate some knowledge of and understanding of how to utilize photographic equipment and techniques such as lighting equipment, and/or off-camera flash, or use it only minimally in the onside challenge; participants show some creativity in staging and photographing subjects.	Participants clearly demonstrate knowledge and understanding of how to utilize photographic equipment and techniques such as lighting equipment, and/or off-camera flash and use it creatively in the on-site challenge; participants show creativity in staging and photographing subjects; participants show a high level of skill in the use of the tools to create high quality images.	

SEMIFINALIST PORTFOLIO/INTERVIEW (80 points) – continued				
Technical Quality (X1)	Photos are out of focus; blurriness is unintentional and does not contribute to the overall composition; photos display incorrect exposure values, white balance, and/or range of tones; there is little or no consideration given to lighting and/or special effects.	Photos are in focus; photos display correct exposure values, white balance, and/or range of tones; images exhibit some attention to lighting and/or the use of special effects.	Photo subject(s) are in sharp focus; blurriness is used effectively to enhance the composition; photos display correct exposure values, white balance, and/or range of tones; images are enhanced by attention to lighting and/or the use of special effects.	
Impact and Theme (X1)	Images are flat and lack emotional depth; viewers are not drawn into the scene; images do not clearly convey the theme/challenge.	Images show some emotional depth; viewers make an emotional connection with the images/pictures and are drawn into the scene or learn something from the subject(s); images convey the competition theme/challenge.	Images show emotional depth; viewers make an instant emotional connection with the pictures and are drawn into the scene or learn something from the subject(s); images cleary convey the competition theme/challenge.	
Portfolio (X1)	A written statement may or may not accompany each photo, and/or the statement includes only some of the photo's meta data (camera make/model, f/stop, exposure time, ISO speed, focal length), and/or an explanation of the relevance of the image to the challenge is not present and/or is written poorly.	A written statement accompanies each photo; statement includes most of the photo's meta data (camera make/model, f/stop, exposure time, ISO speed, focal length); an explanation of the relevance of the image to the challenge is included.	A written statement accompanies each photo; statement includes the photo's meta data (camera make/model, f/stop, exposure time, ISO speed, focal length); an explanation of the relevance of the image to the challenge is presented in a clear and concise manner.	
Interview (X2)	Communication of the design process is unclear, unorganized, and or illogical; leadership and/or 21st century skills are not evident.	Communication of the design process is somewhat logical and clear; leadership and/or 21st century skills are somewhat evident.	Communication of the design process is clear, concise, and logical; leadership and/or 21st century skills are clearly evident.	
			SEMIFINALIST PORTFOLIO/INTERVIEW SUBTOTAL (80 points)	

Rules violations (a deduction of 20% of the total possible points for the above sections) must be initialed by the judge, coordinator, and manager of the event. Record the deduction in the space to the right.

Indicate the rule violated: _____

SEMIFINAL SUBTOTAL (80 points)

To arrive at the TOTAL score, add any subtotals and subtract rules violation points, as necessary. **TOTAL (170 points)**

Comments:

I certify these results to be true and accurate to the best of my knowledge.

JUDGE

Printed name: _____ Signature: _____

PHOTOGRAPHIC TECHNOLOGY EVENT COORDINATOR INSTRUCTIONS

PERSONNEL

A. Event coordinator
B. Assistants for check-in, two (2)
C. Judges:
    1. Preliminary round for portfolios, two (2) or more
    2. Semifinal round, two (2) or more

MATERIALS

A. Coordinator's packet, containing
    1. Event guidelines, one (1) copy for the coordinator and for each judge
    2. TSA Event Coordinator Report
B. Stopwatch
C. Interview questions
D. Tables for entries
E. Tables and chairs for judges
F. Semifinalist on-site problem, one (1) copy for each member and one (1) copy for each judge.
G. Event time line and presentation schedule

RESPONSIBILITIES

PRE-CONFERENCE

A. National TSA will collect entries until 11:59pm ET on a designated date in mid-May. The results are shared with the CRC manager, event coordinator, and assigned judges.
B. Review entries as they are submitted to the designated online storage utility.
C. Manage communication and Pre-conference evaluation (at least two [2] or more judges should be recruited earlier in the year). Coordinate with National TSA and/or the Judge Manager.

AT THE CONFERENCE

A. Attend the mandatory coordinator's meeting at the designated time and location.
B. Report to the CRC room and obtain the coordinator's packet; check the contents.
C. Review the event guidelines and check to see that enough judges/assistants have been scheduled.
D. Inspect the area(s) in which the event is being held for appropriate set-up, including room size, chairs, tables, outlets, etc. Notify the event manager of any potential problems.
E. One (1) hour before the semifinal event is to begin, meet with evaluators to review time limits, procedures, regulations, evaluation, and all other details related to the event. If questions arise that cannot be answered, speak to the event manager before the event begins.
F. Ensure the judges have access to the online judging system.

PRELIMINARY ROUND

A. On the first full day of the conference, post a list of the twelve (12) semifinalists in random order.
B. Create and post a semifinalist sign-up sheet.

SEMIFINAL ROUND

A. Before the on-site challenge session, check the room set-up. There should be enough seating and table space for twelve (12) semifinalists.
B. Participants must provide their own equipment, including computers and cameras.
C. Begin the event at the scheduled time by closing the doors and checking the entry list.
D. Late entries are considered on a case-by-case basis and only when the lateness is caused by circumstances beyond the participant's control.
E. In order to compete, participants must be on the entry list or must have approval of the CRC.
F. All participants should be in the room at this time. Participants registered but not present may be disqualified.

G. Review the on-site challenge and procedures with the participants.

H. Manage the semifinalist session with judges, who may observe participants taking pictures or editing.

I. As participants complete the on-site challenge, keep all laptops in the room for judging and presentation/interviews, and manage the removal of participants' equipment.

J. As participants depart, ensure they sign up for the presentation/interview.

K. Judges independently score the presentation/interview.

L. Participants report at the time and place stated in the conference program for the presentation/interview

M. Decisions about rules violations must be discussed and verified with the judges, event coordinator, and the CRC manager to determine either:

   1. To deduct twenty percent (20%) of the total possible points in this round
   2. To disqualify the entry

   The event coordinator, judges, and CRC manager must initial either of these actions on the rating form.

N. If necessary, manage security and the removal of materials from the event area.